George Smith – the first decipherment of the Flood tablet (1872/1873, 1876)

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- **Author:** George Smith (1840–1876), British Museum
- **Works:**
  1. "The Chaldean Account of the Deluge", *Transactions of the Society of Biblical Archæology* 2 (1873), pp. 213–234. This is the paper read on 3 Dec 1872, the historic first announcement. Source: https://archive.org/details/transactionssoc00englgoog (TSBA vol. 2, Google scan, NOT_IN_COPYRIGHT).
  2. *The Chaldean Account of Genesis* (London: Sampson Low, 1876), ch. XVI "The Story of the Flood and Conclusion" (pp. 263 ff.). Source: https://archive.org/details/chaldeanaccounto00smit (Princeton). Later editions: 1880 rev. by A. H. Sayce (e.g. archive.org cu31924019182777).
  - Not downloaded: *Assyrian Discoveries* (1875), which also has a flood translation: archive.org/details/assyriandiscover00smit_0.
- **Retrieved:** 2026-10-16
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Files

- `transactionssoc00englgoog--TSBA-vol2-1873.pdf` (10 MB, whole volume) + `transactionssoc00englgoog_djvu.ocr.txt`.
- `TSBA-2-1873--Smith-Chaldean-Account-of-the-Deluge.ocr.md`: OCR of the article (uncorrected).
- `chaldeanaccounto00smit--1876.pdf` (17 MB) + `chaldeanaccounto00smit_djvu.ocr.txt`.
- `chaldean-account-1876--ch-XVI-flood.ocr.md`: OCR of ch. XVI (uncorrected).

Line numbering

Smith numbers lines by column (col. i 1–..., etc.), following the K 3375-based arrangement of his time. It does not map directly to modern numbering; align by content.

Assessment

Of **historical interest only**: the first decipherment (1872). The names are early readings that are now obsolete: Izdubar = Gilgamesh, Hasisadra/Sisit = Ūta-napišti (Hasisadra = Atra-hasīs read backwards), Heabani = Enkidu, Nizir. It contains many misreadings. It is useful for the history of the Genesis–Babylon debate ("Babel und Bibel") but not for translation.